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How to Motivate Creative People

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2009

CHAPTER 1

Why Motivation Is Crucial to Creative Performance

Why Motivation Is Crucial to Creative Performance If you are a leader or manager your job is to get the best work out of the people on your team. Traditional approaches to corporate management often rely on 'the carrot and the stick' — offering rewards for good performance, using managerial authority to command people, and penalising failure to comply. But creative work is different. You're probably aware that creative people have a reputation for being free spirits who hate being told what to do.

So it won't surprise you to hear that wielding the big stick will have a negative impact on their work. But did you know that you can do just as much harm with the carrot? What Makes Creative People Different? We all recognise the stereotype of the creative person — brilliant, temperamental, introverted, alternately consumed with pride then racked with self-doubt. Difficult. Eccentric. Possibly mad. Psychologists have devoted enormous efforts to trying to analyse, define and measure the 'creative personality' — but it may interest you to know that they have not had much success.

Where they have succeeded however, is in demonstrating the impact of different types of motivation on the creative process. Harvard Business School professor Teresa Amabile has conducted extensive research into the effect of motivation on creative

performance, particularly in organisational settings. In an article titled 'How to Kill Creativity', she lays out the basic problem: In today's knowledge economy, creativity is more important than ever. But many companies unwittingly employ managerial practices that kill it.

How? By crushing their employees' intrinsic motivation — the strong internal desire to do something based on interests and passions. Managers don't kill creativity on purpose. Yet in the pursuit of productivity, efficiency, and control — all worthy business imperatives — they undermine creativity. It doesn't have to be that way ... business imperatives can comfortably coexist with creativity. But managers will have to change their thinking first. (Theresa Amabile, 'How to Kill Creativity', Harvard Business Review, September-October 1998) Amabile's research has demonstrated that intrinsic motivation is strongly linked to creative performance.

In one experiment she worked with two groups of children. The first group were given paper and paint and told to paint a picture. The second group were told that if they painted a really good picture they would be rewarded with a sweet. When the resulting pictures were evaluated, the first group was judged to have produced consistently better pictures than the second group. Amabile's explanation is that the first group was focused on painting for its own sake (intrinsic motivation) whereas the second group was distracted by the thought of the reward (extrinsic motivation) and so failed to give the painting sufficient attention to produce something

really good.

In another study, described by former advertising creative director Gordon Torr in his book *Managing Creative People*, Amabile and her colleagues invited some art experts to assess the work of 29 professional artists. Unknown to the experts was the fact that each artist had been asked to submit 10 commissioned works and 10 non-commissioned works. Overall, the experts rated the commissioned works as less creative than the others — the only exception being commissions that "enable the artist to do something interesting or exciting", i.e.

in which there was a strong component of intrinsic motivation in addition to the extrinsic motivation that came from the commission. Amabile's research has led her to formulate "the intrinsic motivation principle of creativity": People will be most creative when they feel motivated primarily by the interest, satisfaction, and challenge of the work itself — not by external pressures. (Amabile, 'How to Kill Creativity') These external pressures — i.e. extrinsic motivations — even include 'positive' incentives such as money, since as Amabile points out, "a cash reward can't magically prompt people to find their work interesting if in their hearts they feel it is dull".

So to get the best out of creative workers, managers need to help them discover meaning and interest in their work — over and above their professional obligations and the company's commercial interests. Bad News for Managers You can't improve creative performance by giving people orders, showering them with praise or

paying them more money. Expecting people to do outstanding creative work 'because they are paid to do it' may sound perfectly reasonable — but it doesn't work.

That isn't to say that creative types are not interested in money and other rewards — sadly, it's not that simple. As we'll see in chapter 6, rewards are very important to creative people. Like the creative process itself, creative motivations are complex. To get the best out of creative people you need to understand something of the nature of creativity, the effect of rewards on creative performance, the individual personalities you're dealing with, and the way they interact as a group.

If your job involves getting top performance out of workers engaged on creative projects, you're in a paradoxical position: on the one hand, your success depends on getting them fired up to do their best; but on the other, the traditional management 'levers' — money, status and privilege — may actually do more harm than good. The goal of this e-book is to help you resolve this paradox. Good News for Managers Because creative people are not motivated primarily by money, it's possible to get outstanding performance from them without a limitless budget.

And because there are no simple solutions to motivating creative people, it presents you with a very interesting challenge. If you like the idea of an interesting challenge, it suggests that you too are a creative person. So the idea of finding creative ways to inspire and engage your team will probably appeal to you. The rest of this

e-book aims to stimulate your managerial creativity. 3. What Gets You out of Bed in the Morning?

It is five o'clock in the morning, in the middle of January, in the heart of the Victorian age. An old man is climbing the stairs, lit by a candle on the tray in his hands. The tray also holds a pot of coffee and a china cup. When he reaches the top of the stairs, he pauses for breath and rests the tray on a small table. Straightening, he knocks three times on the bedroom door, picks up the tray and enters.

As he approaches the bed, he can make out a head with an enormous beard spilling over the blanket. The master blinks owlishly as his servant approaches, places the candle on the bedside table and proceeds to pour the coffee. The beard belongs to Anthony Trollope, the acclaimed Victorian novelist, who will author 47 novels in his lifetime, as well as a handful of travel books and numerous short stories.

This would be an impressive output for any writer — yet most of these works were written while Trollope was engaged on a distinguished full-time career in the Post Office. Hence the early mornings, as described in his *Autobiography*: It was my practice to be at my table every morning at 5.30a.m.; and it was also my practice to allow myself no mercy. An old groom, whose business it was to call me, and to whom I paid £5 a year extra for the duty, allowed himself no mercy.

During all those years at Waltham Cross he was never once late with the coffee which it was his duty to bring me. I do not know that

I ought not to feel that I owe more to him than to any one else for the success I have had. By beginning at that hour I could complete my literary work before I dressed for breakfast. (Anthony Trollope, *An Autobiography*, 1883) What went through Trollope's mind as he lay there in bed, hearing the knock at the door and watching his manservant pour the coffee each morning?

How did he feel? What made him get out of bed instead of turning over for another forty winks? Was he thinking of the joy of creation, of his characters and the next chapter in their story? Did he bound out of bed, eager to put pen to paper and lose himself in his imagination? Maybe. It's hard to imagine anyone writing 47 novels without taking some pleasure in the process, and this must have been factored into his plans.

I would guess that once seated at his desk, he was soon absorbed in the pleasure of writing for its own sake — otherwise known as intrinsic motivation. But as he was lying there, acutely aware of the contrast between the warm bed and the cold January air? I'm not so sure. Was he thinking of the money he would make from his books? When the *Autobiography* was published after his death, Trollope's readers were shocked at his frank admission that he wrote for cash.

His reputation suffered when critics condemned him for such base extrinsic motivation. Again, I'm sure that financial reward was a large factor in Trollope's resolve to get up so early each morning. But as he lay there in bed, poised between sleeping and waking? Did gold coins dance before his eyes and lure him to the table? Maybe,

maybe not. Was he simply a very disciplined man, focused on his desire for achievement and made of sterner stuff than ordinary mortals?

In this case, allowing himself "no mercy" would simply be down to his character, his personal motivation. But in that case, why would he need someone else to bring his coffee and get him out of bed? Surely he'd trust himself to get up on his own? Imagine for a moment that you are the great man, lying in that bed. It's nice and warm. You're sleepy. As you poke your hand out from the covers, you can feel the frost in the air.

You'd like nothing more than to roll over and go back to sleep. But what would you tell the servant? "Sorry, it's too cold today"? "I'm tired"? "Can I just have five more minutes?" Or even worse — wake up later to find you nodded off in front of him... Imagine the loss of face! You're awake now, sitting bolt upright, assuming the mantle of head of the household. In a moment you're out of bed and into character, slipping into the dressing gown he holds for you, thanking him for the coffee, making small talk about the weather and the fireplace.

A few short steps and you're ensconced at your writing table, haloed by candlelight. As the manservant leaves the room, you feel a twinge of gratitude, even of solidarity. And appreciation of the effectiveness of this kind of interpersonal motivation. Or maybe it was just the coffee. Trollope's motivation for writing was clearly complex, with different types of motivation playing different roles.

Yes he wanted to make money, but his chosen path must have been influenced by a love of reading and telling stories.

He must have been disciplined and ambitious to plan such a punishing schedule for himself — yet he clearly did not trust himself to stick to it alone. So he set a motivational trap for himself, baiting it with his vanity — at the crucial moment, he knew that he could not stay in bed without humiliating himself in front of his social inferior. No wonder he was so ready to acknowledge the old man's contribution to his success.

Compared to life in a modern creative agency or studio, the creative process in Trollope's bedroom was pretty straightforward. The production work only involved two people, although publishers and the rest of the literary world came into play further down the line. The Victorian Post Office was very advanced for its day, but didn't have to deal with anything approaching the complexity or speed of today's global communications networks. Yet even in such a simple creative system we can trace several different types of motivation.

How much more complex then, are the motivations, drives and influences at play in the 21st century creative economy? Trollope's example shows us that managing yourself is hard enough, but what if you are a manager responsible for the work of many different creative professionals? How can you balance the desires of these famously independent-minded workers with the competing pressures of your organisation, your clients and the marketplace? You know

people do their best work when they are most committed to it — but how do you keep their motivation high when things get tough?

What can you do if you don't have pots of money to throw at the problem? Or when somebody is being paid a small fortune and still doesn't seem interested? If you're a manager, this e-book will offer you practical options for approaching these challenges. Whether or not you manage other people, if creativity is central to your work then it should also help you fine-tune your own motivations, for maximum creative satisfaction and professional success.

4. You Can't Motivate Anybody 'Motivation' is often spoken about as if it were some kind of magic potion that you inject into people, or get them to imbibe before setting to work, like Asterix taking a tot from his hip flask before laying into the Roman legions. According to this view, it's the manager's job to motivate employees, like the stereotypical football coach bellowing at his charges through a microphone.

Sometimes that can be a great idea, but as Arsene Wenger says, you can only really shout at people a couple of times a season if you want it to be effective — if you do it every week they just get used to it and ignore you. And if you have to shout, encourage and cajole your people to put the effort in every week, then something's wrong. I once went to a seminar with psychotherapy guru Bill O'Hanlon where he talked about motivation in therapy.

He drew an analogy with curling, the winter sport in which players take turns to throw a stone across the ice towards a target,

while their teammates sweep the ice in front of it with brushes, to reduce friction and help the stone slide further. According to Bill, it's not the therapist's job to throw the stone — the impetus for change has to come from the client. The therapist's role is to sweep the ice and help the client keep going, facilitating rather than pushing.

I think the same applies to management — if you've got people who put plenty of force and direction into their throw, you can do a fantastic job scrubbing away the ice in front of them. But if there's no energy coming from them, you can sweep all you like but the stone won't move. So you can't 'motivate' anybody else. You can show them the target, smooth the way and cheer them along.

But motivation is something you draw out rather than put in. Unfortunately, You CAN Demotivate People 'Low motivation' is sometimes offered as pseudo-diagnosis of an employee who is not performing as desired. But just about every time I've had the pleasure of working with such a designated 'problem employee' I find them to be incredibly motivated — just not about the things their manager wants them to do. Sometimes they are motivated about stuff that has nothing to do with their work — their allotment, their band, their sports team, their recipe for sweet-and-sour pork or their upcoming ascent of Kangchenjunga.

These are often people in the wrong job, or people who see their job simply as a way to pay the bills. I've encountered fewer of these cases in the creative industries than in other sectors, probably

because the competition for doing sexy creative jobs is usually so fierce that you have to be pretty driven to get in the door in the first place. But sadly I have encountered the other kind of ‘low motivation’ — where someone’s enthusiasm and commitment have been worn down or destroyed altogether by experiences at work, often involving their manager.

Rightly or wrongly, these people have got the impression that their manager doesn’t care about (a) them as a person, (b) their contribution to the team, or both. They’re asking themselves ‘Why should I bother if it doesn’t make any difference?’. And the thing is, the manager often doesn’t realise how little it could take to turn things round. Once upon a time I was managing a software project. At five o’clock the day before our first big demonstration to the client, I received the delivery from the programmers, several days late.

To my horror I discovered a major problem that would involve at least a day’s work to fix. Eager to impress, I stayed up all night to do it, painstakingly cutting and pasting hundreds of photos and captions into place. This wasn’t the first time I had worked late into the night. The next morning, the managing director swept into the office and asked for a preview of the presentation.

Halfway through, he stopped me and pointed out a missing caption — “Who added these captions?” he asked. “Well I did, but —” I started, before he interrupted: “So that’s your fault then, isn’t it?” At that moment, he lost me. I never worked past 5.30 again, let

alone weekends or all nighters. It wasn't long before I started looking for a new job. I was always professional, but I realised it wasn't worth going the extra mile for him.

Looking back on it now, I guess he probably thought he was setting high standards, pushing me to do better next time. He probably never realised he'd shot himself in the foot — and how little it would have taken to maintain my enthusiasm. Going back to the curling analogy: as a manager you can't throw the stone yourself, but you can easily block it if you're not careful. So How Do I Make Sure My People Are Motivated?

You can't. Not 100% sure. As Mark Earls would put it, managers are accelerators and influencers — but ultimately not controllers. People always have a choice. But although you can't guarantee motivation, there are several things you can do to make it more likely. It may sound banal, but the most important thing is to hire motivated people. Remember, you can't put motivation into people, only draw out and amplify what's there already.

Whenever you make a decision to hire or work with someone else, you obviously need to consider their talent, experience and qualifications — but don't forget to ask: How committed is this person to our shared goal? If you can't answer 'very' then you could be in for trouble, no matter how good they look on paper. Once people are on your team, I suggest you ask yourself two basic questions: 1.

How do I tap into their core motivations and amplify them? 2. How do I avoid blocking these motivations? These questions are really two sides of the same coin, but as my example shows, it can be frighteningly easy to fall into the trap of 2 when you think you're doing 1. Four Kinds of Motivation To answer the two questions above, in my next four chapters, I'll consider four different kinds of motivation — the basic levers of influence available to you as a leader or manager: 1.

Intrinsic motivation – the attraction of the work itself 2. Extrinsic motivation – rewards for doing the work 3. Personal motivation – individual values 4. Interpersonal motivation – social influences All four motivations apply to most kinds of work, but I'll explain why I think it's particularly important to get the right balance between them when you're dealing with creative work and workers who see themselves as creative. As well as describing the four types of motivation, I'll suggest some ways that you can use them to facilitate top creative performance.

5. The Joy of Work — Intrinsic Motivation In Seth Godin's new book *Tribes*, he tells the story of being on holiday in Jamaica, unable to sleep and getting up at 4 AM to check his e-mail in the hotel lobby. As he's sitting there quietly minding his own business, a couple of partygoers roll in from a nightclub. One of them gives him a withering look and hisses 'in a harsh whisper a little quieter than a yell': isn't it sad?

That guy comes here on vacation and he's stuck checking his e-mail. He can't even enjoy his two weeks off. And the funny thing is, says Seth, 'Other than sleeping, there was nothing I'd rather have been doing at that moment — because I'm lucky enough to have a job where I get to make change happen'. Seth is a classic case of a worker driven by intrinsic motivation — i.e.

the work is rewarding in itself, something he does for the sheer pleasure of it. Many creative workers say 'I love my work so much I do it for free', but Seth take this further — according to one of his recent blog posts, he goes out of his way to avoid making money from most of his work. I'm not as hardcore as Seth about the money part, but I know how he feels about work.

I love my work. I love reading, writing, researching and thinking of ideas. I love spending time with interesting, challenging, talented creative people. I love making new connections, between people, ideas, skills and resources. I love making things — my